

## Unit 4

### Track 5

*You will hear an expert giving a talk about blogs and blogging. First, you have some time to look at Questions 1–10.*

Pause

*Now listen and answer Questions 1–10.*

OK, I'm going to talk today about blogs and blogging. Though I'm assuming you're all familiar with what a blog is, let's just start with a definition. Perhaps the simplest definition is that a blog is a type of website in the form of a journal of one sort or another. It consists of posts – new material, or entries – that are arranged in chronological order, with the most recent post at the top of the page.

Now, what are the typical characteristics of a blog? Well, blogs are usually written by one person, they are usually updated regularly and they are often, though by no means always, about one particular topic. That topic might be the blogger's own life, as many blogs are personal diaries. But there are blogs on just about any topic you could think of – there are political blogs, news blogs, blogs about a particular hobby, etc., etc.

Now, most blogs are not monologues, because they allow readers to make their own comments on what appears in the blog, or to add their own information to it. In this way, people get into contact with each other, learning from each other, sharing ideas, perhaps making friends or even doing business with each other, wherever they are in the world.

Although blogs are very much part of modern life and there are literally millions of blogs on the web, the history of blogging is a pretty short one. There is some disagreement over what the first blog was, but many people reckon it was an online diary started by a student called Justin Hall in 1994. His site was called *Justin's Home Page*, and he later called it *Links From The Underground*.

At that point, the word 'blog' didn't exist. More websites like his started to spring up, in the form of regularly updated online journals on various subjects, with links to other websites and forums for people to contribute their personal opinions.

In 1997, someone called Jorn Barger first used the term 'web log' to categorise this kind of website, when he launched his own website, *Robot Wisdom*. In 1999, a blogger called Peter Merholz jokingly broke this word up into 'we blog' and therefore invented the term 'blog'. Pretty soon, everyone called the sites 'blogs' and the people writing them 'bloggers'.

Pause

OK, now let's move on to how to run a blog, and what I'm going to do now is to tell you what I think is the best approach to workflow with a blog. First of all, you need to decide on the frequency of your blog posts. Some people do several a day, which is great if you can keep it up, others one a day. Once a week might be enough, but the key question is what the readers of your blog expect. They need to know when they can expect to see a new post on the blog, so whatever schedule you decide on, it's important to stick to it.

When you're going to do a post, start by reading material to find out what's being discussed in friends' blogs, or in other blogs related to the topic of yours. That way you can take these things into account to ensure that your blog is bang up to date.

Then start composing your blog post. If you're doing one that involves research and links, open a file for storing the sources of your information and the links you're going to put in the post. Also consider using pictures. These can make your blog much more attractive than one that's just text. If you use photos from the web, make sure you cite the source in your blog.

When you've completed the post, add some tags. If you don't have the kind of software that enables you to build them into the post, add them at the bottom. Tags are really important for searchability – they can get you new readers who find your blog via the tags.

If you think this is a particularly good post and you're really proud of it, announce it by sending links to it on social networking sites, together with a very brief summary of what it's about.

Then check your blog statistics to see how many people are reading and responding to your blog. Find out who's blogged about your post and reply to them, and give them a proper reply rather than just saying thanks.

After you've done all that, get off your own blog and comment elsewhere. Remember that you're not the only person blogging and putting out new material – there are lots of others doing the same and you should show them some respect by giving them comments and feedback on their posts where you feel it's appropriate.

Well, that's just some advice on being a good blogger. Blogging's obviously a major thing now in the world of electronic media and it's anybody's guess how it will develop in the future.

## Unit 5

### Track 6

*You will hear a man who is interested in doing voluntary work connected with the environment talking to a woman who works for an organisation that runs environmental projects. First, you have some time to look at Questions 1–10.*

Pause

*Now listen and answer Questions 1–10.*

**Hannah** Hello, how can I help you?

**Ryan** Well, I've come in because I want to volunteer for one of your environmental projects. I read something about your organisation in the paper a few days ago and I thought I'd like to get involved.

**H** OK, that sounds good. What's your name?

**R** Ryan.

**H** OK, Ryan, thanks for coming in. I'm Hannah. Now, let me start by telling you something about our organisation and then we can have a look at a few projects that might interest you, after I've found out a bit about you.

**R** Fine.

**H** Right, well as you know, we're called *The Volunteer Agency* and that pretty well explains what we do. We recruit people for a wide range of projects. A lot of our work concerns environmental projects and at the moment we've got 130,000 volunteers working on these projects.

**R** What sort of environmental projects are they?

**H** Well, for example, if you wanted to go abroad, one of our big projects involves gathering information that is used for the protection of marine and forest environments. Volunteers on that do diving or collect biodiversity data on tropical rainforest species.

**R** Sounds exciting. But I think I'd rather stay here, at least to start off with.

**H** OK. Well, here in our own country we've got a big project aimed at clearing up litter in rural areas. The aim of this is to get everyone involved in making sure their local environment is clean and tidy.

**R** Yes, I've seen adverts for that.

**H** Another project involves looking after the National Cycle network, keeping the routes safe and attractive for cyclists. This is part of a bigger scheme concerned with developing sustainable transport systems all across the country.

**R** Interesting ...

**H** Now, if you want to do something in the city, rather than the countryside, within cities we also have the City Farms projects, which involve working with people, plants and animals.

**R** Oh, what are those? Are they real farms? How do they work?

**H** Well, yes, they're real farms and they're an example of a project that relies almost entirely on volunteers. On other projects, you might be working alongside salaried people, but with these, almost everyone is unpaid. In fact, many of our projects have very few, if any, paid staff.

**R** Yes, that's what I thought.

**H** Well, do any of these things sound particularly appealing to you?

**R** Well, as I say, I wasn't thinking of going abroad, and I'm not sure that any of those is exactly the sort of thing I'm really looking for. Sorry!

**H** That's OK, there are lots more things I can tell you about. I'm sure we'll find a project that's right up your street.

**R** Yes, I hope so.

**H** OK, well, let's have a look at a few other possibilities.

Pause

**H** Right, well one thing that might suit you is a scheme called *Wildlife Link*. There are 47 branches of this around the country, with over 24,000 active volunteers, and it's involved in all aspects of nature conservation. Its aim is to protect wildlife in all habitats across the country. Things you can do there include looking after nature reserves, taking part in community gardening and carrying out surveys of wildlife species. Tell me, are you keen to be outdoors?

**R** Yes, I am, and that does sound like the sort of thing I might be really interested in.

**H** OK. Well, here's another project that you might like the sound of. This one's aimed at young people.

**R** Right, tell me about that one.

**H** It's called *Wildlife Watch*, and involves organising groups for young people, getting them to explore and learn about their local environment. There are over 300 groups and around 150,000 members of those groups. As well as running those groups and going out with them, there is a need for volunteers with administrative skills. Is that the sort of thing you might fancy?

**R** Maybe, but I think I'd probably prefer to be more hands-on, doing physical work.

**H** OK. Well, then the organisation called *Action Earth* might be the one for you. They've got a total of 908 projects, involving over 18,000 volunteers. They do all sorts of things, from planting trees to constructing fences and walls and collecting litter, their aim being to improve the local environment in all sorts of ways. How does that sound?

**R** I might well be interested in that.

**H** OK, look, I'll give you some leaflets and contact information, and you can have a think about it all.

**R** That sounds like a good idea. Thanks.

## Unit 6

### Track 7

*You will hear a manager in a museum talking to the staff about machines that are going to be put into the building. First, you have some time to look at Questions 1–10.*

Pause

*Now listen and answer Questions 1–10.*

OK, now what we need to discuss next is vending machines. Now that the building has been completely refurbished, and we're going to be reopening, we should think of what kind of machines we need. These have two functions, of course – they provide services for visitors and they raise money. Every time someone buys something from the machine, we raise a little more money.

Well, first of all a cash machine seems like a good idea, so that people can get some money to spend while they're in the building, and this will help to keep down queues in the gift shop if everyone is paying with cards. That can go in the entrance hall – we thought about putting it in on the front wall outside the building but decided against that.

Now, we've also decided to install a ticket machine for the individual exhibitions in the various parts of the building. This will take some pressure off the ticket office and reduce the number of people hanging about in the entrance hall. It'll be a simple device – you select the exhibition and then pay for it in cash or by card and it'll be right next to the reception desk, with a sign above it so that people can clearly see it when they arrive.

Now the next machine lots of people might not approve of – a games machine for children to use. I know that this might not seem like the right sort of thing to have in a museum, but a constant complaint we get from visitors is that their visit is spoiled by the sound of bored children running around the corridors and shouting and generally disturbing the atmosphere. If we put a couple of these in the Visitor Centre, well away from the Exhibition Halls, it'll keep some of them occupied.

Then there's the question of a drinks machine. Well, we want as many people as possible to buy our own food and drink in the cafeteria and restaurant, but at the same time visitors will want something to drink when they're going round the museum and are not near to either of those places. We thought a good place for this would be by the lifts on the first floor as people go up and down from one exhibition to another and, of course, that's also right at the top of the stairs.

Pause

Now, the last thing is the drinks machine that we're putting in the staff room. As you'll be using this brand new state-of-the-art machine pretty frequently, I thought I'd just run through with you how it works. So, here on the screen I've put up a picture of it and I'll just tell you all how it works. Well, it's pretty big and you may be surprised to hear that it can store as many as 495 drinks products, so there'll be plenty to choose from and it won't need refilling too regularly.

Right, well, it's got a glass front here and behind it all the drinks, of course. The drinks come in bottles and cans and they're, of course, refrigerated. Now this machine has an interesting feature that I'm sure will entertain you all. When you've chosen and paid for your drink, there's a special rapid pick-up mechanism that grabs your drink and places it into the receiver, here, which is illuminated. So you can see your drink even if it's dark in here. And that's not all.

Through the glass front you can actually see the mechanism working – there's a visible moving arm that gets and delivers the drink and you can see that happening. Now, that's not just to make the machine interesting to look at while you're buying a drink, it's got a serious advantage too. What it does is to quickly and safely move the drink without it being shaken at all. So it won't bubble up or spill when you open it.

Now to the business of how you buy a drink. How it works is that you choose the drink you want from the menu here and then type in the code for that drink – you'll see the code in front of each drink. Then the price of the drink will be displayed here and you pay for it. You can do that with coins or by card. And you can order up to ten products at a time, for example, if you're getting drinks for a group of visitors or colleagues.

So, as I say, it's the very latest in drinks machine technology and I hope you'll all be pleased to have it.

Right, next I'm going to move on to talk about ...

## Unit 7

### Track 8

*You will hear two students talking about a presentation that one of them is going to give. First, you have some time to look at Questions 1–10.*

Pause

*Now listen and answer Questions 1–10.*

**Jack** Hi Maya, how are you getting on with your presentation?

**Maya** Oh, hi Jack. It's going really well after a slow start.

**J** What's it about again?

**M** Well, the general topic area is Human Relationships and we had to choose a specific area within that.

**J** So, what have you chosen?

**M** Lifelong Friendships.

**J** Interesting. What led you to choose that?

**M** Well, it occurred to me that there's been a lot of research on how people form friendships, and even more on marriage and partnerships, but there's not much on this particular topic. So, I thought I could do something a bit different by focusing on this particular aspect.

**J** Sounds like a good idea. How have you been doing your research?

**M** Well, mainly by personal contact. I realised that my parents have a number of lifelong friends, and of course, I've known them for years, so I thought I'd start off by seeing what they had to say.

**J** Sounds reasonable, but that's only a very small sample, isn't it?

**M** Yes, but I thought I'd collate the results from that small sample so that I could compare them with more general conclusions from research in the area.

**J** Good idea. How did you get on when you tried to get information from your subjects?

**M** Well, I started off by giving them a questionnaire. I spent quite some time working that out, deciding what aspects of their friendships I wanted them to focus on and then I handed it out to them.

**J** And?

**M** Well, it didn't work out too well. I kept asking for them back and they kept saying they hadn't had time to do them or hadn't quite finished them, and eventually one or two of them admitted that they were having trouble knowing what to put.

**J** Oh, why's that?

**M** They just couldn't analyse their friendships in that 'cold' way, on paper, in nice, neat little paragraphs or by ticking boxes. I realised then that they all felt that way, so I had to abandon that approach.

**J** What did you do instead?

**M** Personal interviews. I adapted my questionnaire and sat down with each person and talked to them. I got them to agree to my recording these interviews – that way I could focus on the way the interview went rather than having to write notes all the time – and then I went through the recordings.

**J** And that worked out well?

**M** Yes, I got all the information I needed. It was a small sample, as I say, but it was possible to get some general conclusions from them about their lifelong friendships.

**J** And then you compared this with research data?

**M** Yes, there's not a lot of that, but I managed to locate some academic research in the area.

**J** And how did that compare with your findings?

**M** Remarkably similar actually, so my sample proved to be pretty representative. There were one or two disparities here and there, but in general the research I was able to locate pretty much confirmed what I found myself.

Pause

**J** Now, when you do your presentation, how have you organised it?

**M** Well, obviously I've given that a lot of thought, and the various stages of the presentation are linked to the aspects I focused on when I was talking to my subjects. So, obviously, I start with how the friendship was first formed, for example, how old the people were, where they met, how they met, that kind of thing.

**J** How will you present that?

**M** I've created a table, with the various headings and the percentages of my subjects whose friendships started in the various ways.

**J** OK, what comes next?

**M** Well, I've looked at the effects on the friendship of various developments in the friends' lives. The first category I've called 'Change of Location', and that deals with what happens in the friendship if one or other of the friends goes to live somewhere else.

**J** What about if they don't change the place where they live but go to work or study somewhere else?

**M** Well, that's included in my data in that category, in a couple of separate tables.

**J** What then?

**M** OK, well then, I've looked at what happens to the friendship when one or both of the friends get married. I got the subjects to say simply whether marriage meant that friendships got less close, closer or stayed much the same.

- J** How have you presented that data?
- M** That's a pie chart.
- J** OK. What other aspects of the friendship have you focused on?
- M** Well, the next one concerns 'Personality'. I asked people to tick boxes for their friend's personality when they first met, and then how they would describe the same person now.
- J** How did you compare the answers there?
- M** Yea, that was tricky to work out. I looked for patterns of change. One finding from that was that many people who were described as 'relaxed' at the beginning of the friendship got categorised as 'stressed' right now. So, for the presentation, I picked out the most extreme changes that I found, not every single change.
- J** Sounds interesting. Any other categories?
- M** Yes, two more. I thought it would be interesting to compare how much people had in common in terms of political opinions as their friendship progressed over the years. Did they both change them, or did one person change and if so, did this cause tension or disagreement between them? I've constructed another pie chart for that.
- J** And the other category?
- M** Yes, I thought another key area concerned what the people have in common and whether they continue to have those things in common. I've categorised this as 'Shared Interests', and I've looked at any changes that tend to happen over the years. One thing I found, for example, was that men's shared passion for certain sports doesn't change at all over the years, whereas their musical tastes do.
- J** All sounds great. I'm sure it'll go well when you do the presentation.
- M** Thanks. I hope so.

## Unit 8

### Track 9

*You will hear part of a lecture about the history of jeans. First, you have some time to look at Questions 1–10.*

Pause

*Now listen and answer Questions 1–10.*

OK, today we're looking at contemporary fashion 'icons' as part of the module on the history and development of fashion. And perhaps the best place to start with this is with a garment that everybody in the world knows about and either wears or has worn – jeans.

Now, of course, jeans are often synonymous with the word 'denim', for the material they're made from. Where do both these terms come from? Well, there isn't universal agreement on either of these things, but the story begins in Europe in the 1500s. The general belief is that the word 'jeans' comes from Genoa in Italy, where sailors wore clothes made from a material called jean.

The word 'denim' is generally considered to come from France at roughly the same time. It is thought to have evolved from 'serge de Nîmes', a kind of material produced in the French town of Nîmes. These two fabrics were different in important ways. Denim was stronger and more expensive than jean. And denim was woven with one coloured thread and one white thread, while jean was woven with two coloured threads.

To start with, the cloth for both of them was a mixture of things. By the 18th century, however, it was made completely from cotton. And it was dark blue because it was dyed with indigo, which was taken from plants in the Americas and India. Denim and jean remained two very different fabrics and by the late 19th century it was denim that had emerged as the most popular and widely worn. Denim was used for workers' clothes, for example, those worn by workers on plantations, because it was very strong and it lasted for a long time. Jean was used for lighter clothes. Eventually of course, the word 'jeans' would come to be used for clothes made from denim, but that's much later.

A key event in the history of jeans was the 1848 Gold Rush, when gold was found in California and thousands of gold miners rushed there to find it and make their fortunes. They wanted clothes that were strong and didn't tear easily. Enter a man called Strauss. He moved to California from New York and started a business supplying work clothes. His first name was Leob, that's L-E-O-B. Later, he changed it to Levi.

Now, the miners in California were experiencing a problem with their work clothes. The pockets tore away from them very easily; they just weren't strong enough or well enough attached. In 1872, a man called Jacob Davis wrote to Strauss about an idea he'd had.

This was for metal rivets to hold the pockets and the rest of the garment together, and he offered Strauss a deal to use this idea in the clothes he was supplying. Strauss accepted the offer and started to make work clothes with these metal fasteners, made of copper. They weren't called jeans at this time, that term didn't come into being until the 1960s – they were sold as 'waist overalls' and made with denim.

In 1886, Strauss added another feature to these clothes, a leather label. To emphasize how strong the garments were, this showed a pair of these trousers being pulled between two horses. The message was that they were so strong that even this could not cause them to tear. By the 1920s, because of their reputation for toughness, Strauss's waist overalls were the most widely used workers' trousers in the U.S.

Now, up until the 1930s, jeans were purely and simply work clothes. But Hollywood changed all that and they made the journey to being fashion items. The roots of this lie in the cowboy movies of the 1930s. Cowboys often wore jeans in these movies, and American men wanted to dress like them in their free time. At this point, jeans are a wholly American thing.

The Second World War in the 1940s took them abroad, as American soldiers wore them when they were off duty. This introduced them to the wider world. But their real popularity as a fashion item really starts in the 1950s, when they caught on with young people. This was because they became the symbol of the teenage rebel. This completely new type of young person emerged in American films and TV programmes that were enormously popular with teenagers. Teenagers didn't call the clothes 'waist overalls', they gave them a new name – 'jean pants'. And pretty soon, this got abbreviated to jeans.

In the 1960s, jeans were the standard kind of trousers worn by students in Western countries and they were the top fashion item. Young people adapted them in all sorts of ways, turning them into embroidered jeans by sewing brightly coloured designs on to them, and all sorts of styles emerged, one of the main ones being flared jeans, with bottoms that got wider and wider as they went down.

Right, now I'm going to move on to look at what jeans symbolised both in Western countries and in non-Western countries at that time. But first of all, does anyone have any questions?